

NT30 Enrichment

†1. **Cornelius:** “A centurion at Caesarea, baptized by Peter (Acts 10). The significance of Cornelius’s baptism is that he was probably the first Gentile to come into the Church not having previously become a proselyte to Judaism (see Proselytes). Other Gentiles had joined the Church, but they had been converted to Judaism before becoming Christians, which caused no great commotion among Jewish Christians who thought of Christianity as having some ties with Judaism.

“Preceding the baptism of Cornelius, there were several spiritual manifestations: the ministry of an angel to Cornelius; a vision to Peter showing that the dietary restrictions of the law of Moses were to be discontinued; the voice of the Spirit to Peter; and a manifestation of the power of the Holy Ghost, accompanied by the speaking in tongues. All of this would make clear the divine approval and direction of what was about to take place.

“The baptism of Cornelius and his family marked a new dimension in the work of the Church in New Testament times, since it opened the way for the gospel to be preached to the Gentiles directly, without going by way of Judaism. It is notable that this major event in the missionary activity of the Church was done through the ministry of Peter, the chief Apostle, who held the keys of the kingdom of God at that time on the earth.” (Bible Dictionary: “[Cornelius](#).”

†2. **Gentiles Are Welcomed Into The Early Christian Church:** “All through his ministry, Jesus specifically forbade his disciples from preaching the gospel to Gentiles: “Go not into the way of the Gentiles, and into any city of the Samaritans enter ye not” (Matt. 10:5). But there were hints that the Gentiles would one day be included. Matthew took effort to make this apparent in his gospel, from the very beginning, in the second chapter, where he tells of the faith of the wise men from the east: their study of the scriptures, their understanding of Christ and his importance, their warning in a dream that saved the life of the baby Jesus. Their righteousness and perceptiveness stands in contrast to that of the common Jews who had no room in the inn, and the Jewish king, Herod, who wanted the infant Christ killed.

“Throughout Jesus’ three-year ministry there are a handful of stories of Gentiles who were faithful enough to receive miracles at the hand of Christ. And there are parables Christ told, in which the Gentiles are allowed to take the place of the Jews--such as the parable of the marriage of the king’s son. These should have prepared the disciples for the idea that the gospel would not be the Jews’ private property for long.

“Then, at the very end of Matthew, the closing verses are Christ’s injunction to the disciples, “Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost” (Matt. 28:19). The word “nations” in this scripture is translated from a Greek word “ethnos,”

which in the Greek Old Testament is used to specifically designate a pagan or Gentile people (Streathern, p. 189).

“So it should have been pretty clear to the disciples that the directive to teach the gospel only to the Jews had been expanded so that the blessings of the gospel could be made available to everyone in the world. Indeed, Peter, John and Philip all followed this commission quite quickly, as in Chapter 8 of Acts we find all three of them teaching the gospel in the cities of the Samaritans, and Philip also teaching the gospel to the Ethiopian.

“But there was something about this change in policy that was not well understood by the disciples, and definitely not understood by many of the Jewish Christians. The second part of the injunction to preach to the Gentiles says, “...teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you...” (Matt. 28:20). Did that include the Law of Moses? Did you have to convert to Judaism first, and then convert to Christianity?”

“This was the question that was answered definitively by the vision given to Peter in Acts 10... “(Nancy Jensen, New Testament Lesson #30 “[God is No Respector of Persons](#),” at LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus, July 23, 2011.)

†3. **Clean and Unclean: Gospel to the Gentiles:** “Peter received a vision where the Lord showed him a blanket full of unclean animals. Commanded to eat, Peter insisted that he was not supposed to touch unclean things. Three times, the food was shown to him, with a heavenly voice explaining that which the Lord has made clean is no longer unclean.

“Commanded to follow the servants of Cornelius who sought him, Peter went with them. This would be a learning experience for both Gentile and apostle:

“ ‘And he (Peter) said unto them, Ye know how that it is an unlawful thing for a man that is a Jew to keep company, or come unto one of another nation; but God hath shewed me that I should not call any man common or unclean’ (Acts 10:28).

“Peter could be stoned to death by the Jews for being entertained in the house of a Gentile, in this case, Cornelius the Roman centurion. Peter taught the gospel, particularly concerning the Messiah, Jesus Christ. As he taught them, the Holy Ghost fell upon all in the house. All of the Jewish Christians were amazed that the Holy Ghost would fall upon Gentiles. Peter saw this as God’s sign that Cornelius’ household had been cleansed. They were no longer “common or unclean.” He insisted they be baptized into the Church.

“This moment creates a major change in the early Christian Church. From this moment forward, it is no longer a Jewish sect, but will become a separate religion of its own. From Cornelius’ conversion onward, key decisions would be made in the Church that would cause an ever widening gulf between it and its Jewish roots.” (Gerald Smith, “[New Testament Gospel Doctrine Lesson 30: ‘God Is No Respector of Persons](#),” July 19, 2011.

†4. **Difference between the ‘Grecians and the ‘Hebrews’:** “But the difference between the ‘Grecians’ and the ‘Hebrews’ was far deeper than merely of language, and extended to the whole direction of thought. There were mental influences at work in the Greek world from which, in the nature of things, it was impossible even for Jews to withdraw themselves... it was only natural that the Hellenists, placed as they were in the midst of such hostile elements, should intensely wish to be Jews, equal to their Eastern brethren. On the other hand, Pharisaism, in its pride of legal purity and of the possession of traditional lore, with all that it involved, made no secret of its contempt for the Hellenists, and openly declared the Grecian far inferior to the Babylonian ‘dispersion.’ That such feelings, and the suspicions which they engendered, had struck deep into the popular mind, appears from the fact, that even in the Apostolic Church, and that in her earliest days, disputes could break between the Hellenists and the Hebrews, arising from suspicion of unkind and unfair dealings grounded on these sectional prejudices (Acts 6:1).” (Edersheim, Alfred, *Life and Times of Jesus the Messiah*, 5-6, cited in Monte Shelley’s Notes, “[NT 30: ‘Gospel spreads from Jews to Gentiles.’](#)” 21 Aug 2011.)

†5. **Token of Abrahamic Covenant (Slide 11):**

- **Circumcision** - Token of Abraham’s and every male descendant’s covenant (Genesis 17:3-7; 10-11)
- *Circumcision* – Latin words meaning “to cut around”
- Not the act itself but rather what it stood for that gave circumcision its great significance. Though a person may have had the token of circumcision in the flesh, unless he was righteous the covenant was invalidated and the circumcision became profitless. Thus, circumcision was only a sign or token of what needed to happen to the inward man. If the inward change had not taken place, then circumcision was virtually meaningless.
- True circumcision is of the heart. The heart that is “circumcised” is one that loves God and is obedient to the Spirit. The “uncircumcised in heart” are wicked, proud, and rebellious.

(Frances Hume, Lesson 30 Power Point Presentation, “fh-2007-nt-30.ppt.” Go to ldsgospeldoctrine.net for New Testament Lesson 30. Click on Francis Hume.)

†6. **President Kimball speaking to saints in South**

Africa: “As you know, on the ninth of June a policy was changed that affects great numbers of people throughout the world. Millions and millions of people will be affected by the revelation which came. I remember very vividly that day after day I walked to the temple and ascended to the fourth floor where we have our solemn assemblies and where we have our meetings of the Twelve and the First Presidency. After everybody had gone out of the temple, I knelt and prayed. I prayed with

much fervency. I knew that something was before us that was extremely important to many of the children of God. I knew that we could receive the revelations of the Lord only by being worthy and ready for them and ready to accept them and put them into place. Day after day I went alone and with great solemnity and seriousness in the upper rooms of the temple, and there I offered my soul and offered my efforts to go forward with the program. I wanted to do what he wanted. I talked about it to him and said, ‘Lord, I want only what is right. We are not making any plans to be spectacularly moving. We want only the thing that thou dost want, and we want it when you want it and not until.’

“We met with the Council of the Twelve Apostles, time after time in the holy room where there is a picture of the Savior in many different moods and also pictures of all the Presidents of the Church. Finally we had the feeling and the impression from the Lord, who made it very clear to us, that this was the thing to do to make the gospel universal to all worthy people. You will meet this situation undoubtedly as you bring the gospel to them on condition that their lives can be changed.

“I anticipate the day when the gospel, that has come to you and your families and has transformed your lives, will begin to transform their lives and make new people out of them. They become people who will love the Lord and who will make the same sacrifices that you make” (*Teachings of Spencer W. Kimball*, pp. 450-451, cited by Ted L. Gibbons, “[New Testament Lesson 30: God Is No Respector of Persons.](#)” @ LDSLiving.com).

Recommended Reading:

1. Ted L. Gibbons, “[New Testament Lesson 30: God Is No Respector of Persons.](#)” @ LDSLiving.com).
2. Nancy Jensen, “[New Testament Lesson #30 ‘God is No Respector of Persons.’](#)” @ LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus, July 23, 2011.
3. Gerald Smith, “[New Testament Gospel Doctrine Lesson 30: ‘God Is No Respector of Persons.’](#)” July 19, 2011.
4. [BYU Studies](#), “[30. ‘God Is No Respector of Persons.’](#)” accessed 8/7/15. Both of these links are to articles that are free.
5. Taylor Halverson, “[Lesson 30: ‘God Is No Respector of Persons.’](#)” July 27, 2015 at Meridian Magazine.
6. Monte F. Shelley, “[NT 30: Gospel spreads from Jews to Gentiles.](#)” 21 Aug 2011.

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